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PRIYANKA CHOPRA
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“Most students at INSEAD were engineers. Being an engineer was a plus, but having peers from other streams helped in overall learning”

RAJIV MEHTA
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predictable outcome backed by a high level of logic. This now needed a very flipped intuition,” he says. Like Bansal, he says failure and its acceptance were key learnings.

THE TRANSFORMATION

The choice of a business school is driven by multiple factors. In case of Bansal, Stanford’s location was important, by way of what she terms “proximity to innovation”. Much of the world’s innovation over the last few decades, according to her, has originated in Silicon Valley. “The opportunity to live and learn at the very centre of that ecosystem, to absorb its entrepreneurial mindset and openness to experimentation, was incredibly compelling. It was a major reason to choose Stanford over

Harvard, having acceptances from both schools.”

It is not uncommon for students to want to study at best business schools and hence apply to a small number of schools. In case of Priyanka Chopra, CEO & Managing Partner, IIMA Ventures and venture partner, Bharat Innovation Fund, her consideration set was limited to three: the school’s reputation, diversity and class size; quality of faculty, alumni network, industry connections, especially in technology and finally, the placement record. “I was also an expectant mother at the time of being accepted. Wharton’s (The Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania) supportive and flexible approach tilted the scale in its favour,” she says.

One incident during that phase is etched in her mind. There was a challenge to balance motherhood and the demands of a rigorous academic programme. Chopra recalls “a remarkable woman” who was a grandmother and CEO, sharing a piece of advice. “Think of your career as a dimmer switch and not an on/off button. Never switch it off and dim it when your family needs you and turn it up when you are ready to go full throttle,” she says. For her, the learning was that one does not have to choose between ambition and balance.

Inevitably, the transformation during the MBA for many people took off when a preconceived notion was shattered. For Bansal, an expectation of rigour eventually led to something “much deeper and more personal.” She calls the two years “profoundly transformative” and how they humbled her. The world experience included a summer in Bhutan, working with the king on development initiatives and later with Mumbai High Court’s Chief Justice, which exposed her to public policy and governance.

Not surprisingly, for anyone from a middle-class family in India, it was critical to adapt. Tewari values Harvard for changing him from “that Kanpur boy” to thinking of the world differently. “The environment at Harvard was people thinking and talking about changing the world,” he says.

The global order may be shifting, but it will be worth watching whether the overseas MBA retains its shine. Chances are, that isn’t going to change anytime soon. **BT**

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